Case ETH-SEC-002 - Ethiopia's Military Capability and Regional Alignments in the Horn of Africa

Status: open-source research case + fictional simulation inputs

As of: 1 November 2026

Geographic scope: Ethiopia, Eritrea, Somalia, Somaliland (disputed status), Djibouti, Egypt, Türkiye, Saudi Arabia, United Arab Emirates, Israel

Purpose: graph extraction of documented alignments and scenario exploration in M2 Swarm

Research integrity. Named officials, parties and governments appear only through reported public positions at cited dates. All persona comments in the synthetic section are written for simulation: they are not quotations, not scraped posts, not real people, not polling data and not predictions. Contested figures are given as ranges with their sources. Where sources disagree, both are recorded. Capability information is limited to publicly reported acquisitions and agreements; it contains no operational, deployment or targeting detail, and unconfirmed reports are flagged as such.

1. Case question

What military capabilities has Ethiopia publicly acquired or developed since 2018, and how have its relationships with Eritrea, Somalia, Egypt, Türkiye, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and Israel shifted, particularly around the Red Sea, the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD) and Somaliland? Which documented alignments support or constrain Ethiopia's stated goals?

2. Analytical boundaries

- Use only open-source reporting; flag single-source or unconfirmed claims (for example, UAE drone supply).
- Published force-size estimates differ widely and are omitted; do not invent numbers.
- A defence agreement, a summit or a diplomatic statement is not an alliance; record what was actually signed or said.
- Do not infer coordination between two states because they appear in the same article.
- Treat Somaliland's status as disputed; Israel's recognition is recorded with the regional reactions to it.
- Synthetic personas are fictional; real governments and officials are context-only in simulations.

3. Documented timeline

Each line is a sourced statement. Items marked *[verify]* are widely reported but were not re-checked against a primary source for this file; confirm before approving them in the graph.

- **16 September 2018.** Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed and President Isaias Afwerki signed a peace agreement in Jeddah, hosted by Saudi Arabia, with the United Arab Emirates acting as a facilitator. (S01, S02)
- **12 March 2019.** Ethiopia and France signed a defence cooperation agreement that included support for a future Ethiopian navy; later reporting said no vessels had been exported under it. (S03)
- **2021.** Satellite imagery analysed by PAX showed Turkish Bayraktar TB2, Chinese Wing Loong and Iranian Mohajer-6 drones at Ethiopian air bases; supply of Wing Loong drones by the UAE was described as likely but not confirmed. (S04, S05)
- **Summer 2021.** According to the US State Department, Iran delivered Mohajer-6 armed drones to Ethiopia. (S06)
- **2024.** Reporting said the Ethiopian Air Force received Russian Su-30 fighter aircraft and Turkish Akinci drones; the exact delivery date should be confirmed. (S07 [verify])
- **1 January 2024.** Ethiopia and Somaliland signed a memorandum of understanding on sea access; Somalia rejected it on sovereignty grounds. (S08)

- **8 February 2024.** Somalia and Türkiye signed a defence and economic cooperation agreement under which Türkiye would help build, train and equip the Somali navy; the full text was not published. (S09)
- **August 2024.** Egypt and Somalia signed a defence pact and military cooperation protocol in Cairo. (S10)
- **10 October 2024.** The presidents of Egypt, Eritrea and Somalia met in Asmara and pledged to strengthen security cooperation and support Somalia's territorial integrity. (S10, S11)
- **11 December 2024.** Ethiopia and Somalia agreed the Ankara Declaration, facilitated by Türkiye, on a commercial access pathway under Somali sovereignty. (S12)
- **March-May 2025.** Ethiopia's foreign minister visited Israel in March 2025, and Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Sa'ar met Prime Minister Abiy in Addis Ababa in May 2025. (S13)
- **9 September 2025.** Ethiopia inaugurated the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam; Egypt protested to the UN Security Council and called the dam a unilateral step. (S14)
- **26 December 2025.** Israel recognised Somaliland as an independent state; Somalia, Egypt, Türkiye and Djibouti condemned the decision, the African Union reaffirmed Somalia's unity and Saudi Arabia affirmed Somalia's territorial integrity. (S15, S16)
- **24-25 February 2026.** Israeli President Isaac Herzog made a state visit to Addis Ababa. (S17)
- **February 2026.** Reporting described rising Ethiopia-Eritrea tensions and fears of armed confrontation. (S18)

4. Actor perspectives (documented)

Ethiopia (ENDF, Ethiopian Air Force)

Expanded drone and air capabilities since 2021 from several suppliers; seeks a navy and sea access; states a preference for peaceful negotiation. Sources S03-S07.

Eritrea

Signed peace with Ethiopia in 2018 and fought alongside federal forces in Tigray; joined the 2024 Asmara summit with Egypt and Somalia; relations with Addis Ababa deteriorated by 2025-2026. Sources S01, S11, S18.

Somalia

Rejected the 2024 Somaliland memorandum; signed defence agreements with Türkiye and Egypt; agreed the Ankara Declaration with Ethiopia. Sources S08-S12.

Egypt

Opposes the GERD's unilateral operation; signed a defence pact with Somalia; condemned Israel's recognition of Somaliland. Sources S10, S14, S15.

Türkiye

Reported supplier of TB2 and Akinci drones to Ethiopia; defence partner of Somalia; facilitated the Ankara Declaration; condemned recognition of Somaliland. Sources S04, S07, S09, S12, S15.

Saudi Arabia

Hosted the 2018 Jeddah peace signing; affirmed Somalia's territorial integrity in December 2025. Sources S01, S16.

United Arab Emirates

Facilitated the 2018 rapprochement and announced investment plans; reported but unconfirmed drone supply to Ethiopia. Sources S02, S04.

Israel

Long-standing ties with Ethiopia, high-level visits in 2025-2026; first state to recognise Somaliland. Sources S13, S15, S17.

5. Alignment summary (documented, not alliances)

Ethiopia has diversified arms suppliers (Türkiye, China, Iran and Russia are reported) rather than relying on one partner.

A grouping of Egypt, Eritrea and Somalia formed around security cooperation in 2024; analysts linked it to tensions with Ethiopia, while sources differ on how binding it is.

Türkiye holds ties with both Ethiopia and Somalia and acted as mediator through the Ankara Declaration.

Gulf states have acted as hosts, facilitators and investors; their positions on Somaliland and the Red Sea differ by case.

6. Entity categories and relationships

Entity categories: Country, Organization (armed forces, ministries, African Union), Person (heads of state and ministers at cited dates), Location (ports, bases, the Red Sea), Event (summits, signings, inaugurations), Policy (agreements, memoranda, declarations), Topic (sea access, GERD, drones, Somaliland).

Relationship examples: COUNTRY -NEGOTIATES_WITH-> COUNTRY; COUNTRY -SUPPORTS-> POLICY; COUNTRY -OPPOSES-> POLICY; COUNTRY -HOSTS-> EVENT; ORGANIZATION -PARTICIPATED_IN-> EVENT. Arms transfers are recorded as reported events with their source and confidence, never as confirmed facts when the source says otherwise.

7. Synthetic persona archetypes (fictional - for simulation only)

All personas below are fictional archetypes for M2 Swarm testing; they are not real people or real posts. Stance axis for this case: -1.0 = sees Ethiopia's military build-up and sea-access push as a regional threat, +1.0 = sees it as legitimate and stabilising.

Topic codes: T01 deterrence and security; T02 sovereignty and recognition; T03 Nile and GERD; T04 cooperation and trade corridors.

- **SIM01 - Ethiopian defence-policy student (Ethiopia; government-aligned)** [stance +0.7]: “A modern air force and a future navy are about protecting trade routes, not threatening anyone.” [simulation topic T01]
- **SIM02 - Ethiopian exporter (Ethiopia; pragmatic)** [stance +0.4]: “I care about secure shipping lanes. Security partnerships matter if they keep costs down.” [simulation topic T04]
- **SIM03 - Ethiopian opposition commentator (Ethiopia; government-critical)** [stance -0.4]: “Spending on drones and jets should be weighed against inflation and conflicts at home.” [simulation topic T01]
- **SIM04 - Tigrayan civil-society member (Tigray, Ethiopia; TPLF-aligned)** [stance -0.6]: “We have seen what drones do to civilians. Any build-up worries communities near the border.” [simulation topic T01]
- **SIM05 - Egyptian water engineer (Egypt; GERD-concerned)** [stance -0.6]: “Egypt needs a binding agreement on filling and operations. Statements are not guarantees.” [simulation topic T03]
- **SIM06 - Egyptian journalist (Egypt; sovereignty-focused)** [stance -0.5]: “Red Sea security concerns every coastal state, which is why Egypt works with Somalia and Eritrea.” [simulation topic T02]
- **SIM07 - Somali university lecturer (Somalia; sovereignty-focused)** [stance -0.6]: “Any port arrangement must respect Somalia's borders. The Ankara process showed that dialogue works.” [simulation topic T02]
- **SIM08 - Somaliland trader (Somaliland; recognition-supportive)** [stance +0.5]: “Recognition and trade with Ethiopia would bring jobs, but we also need stability with our neighbours.” [simulation topic T02]
- **SIM09 - Eritrean diaspora writer (Eritrean diaspora; security-focused)** [stance -0.7]: “Talk about the Red Sea makes people in Assab anxious. Sovereignty is not negotiable.” [simulation topic T02]
- **SIM10 - Djiboutian port manager (Djibouti; commercial)** [stance +0.2]: “Djibouti serves Ethiopia's trade today. Competition is fine; instability is bad for everyone.” [simulation topic T04]
- **SIM11 - Turkish foreign-policy analyst (Türkiye; mediation-focused)** [stance +0.2]: “Ankara can talk to both Addis Ababa and Mogadishu. That bridge role is worth protecting.” [simulation topic T04]
- **SIM12 - Gulf investment consultant (United Arab Emirates; investment-focused)** [stance +0.3]: “Capital follows predictable corridors. Investors want de-escalation more than any one outcome.” [simulation topic T04]
- **SIM13 - Saudi Red Sea researcher (Saudi Arabia; stability-focused)** [stance +0.0]: “The priority is a calm Red Sea and respect for recognised borders, including Somalia's.” [simulation topic T02]
- **SIM14 - Israeli Africa-policy researcher (Israel; partnership-focused)** [stance +0.4]: “Ethiopia is a long-standing partner. Agriculture and technology ties matter as much as security.” [simulation topic T04]
- **SIM15 - Regional peace researcher (Regional; analytical)** [stance +0.0]: “Overlapping pacts make miscalculation more likely. Confidence-building measures are overdue.” [simulation topic T01]

8. Test scenarios (hypothetical)

- **Scenario 1 - Red Sea access talks resume.** Ethiopia and a coastal state open talks on a commercial corridor; observe how security-focused and trade-focused personas respond.
- **Scenario 2 - GERD negotiations restart.** A new round of Nile talks is announced; test whether cooperation topics gain over security framing.
- **Scenario 3 - Recognition cascade.** A second state signals recognition of Somaliland; compare sovereignty and trade reactions.

- **Scenario 4 - Capability misinformation.** A false claim about a new weapons delivery circulates; test verification and correction behaviour without attributing invented statements to real governments.

9. Suggested M2 Swarm settings

Field	Value
Case title	Ethiopia's Military Capability and Regional Alignments (ETH-SEC-002)
Research question	Section 1 of this document.
Primary scope	Country
Tags	ethiopia, horn of africa, red sea, egypt, eritrea, somalia, turkiye, saudi arabia, uae, israel, gerd
Entity types	All seven
Environment	Focus issue: Red Sea / sea access; real governments context-only; import section 7 personas
Simulation	24 rounds; 1-2 LLM-written posts per round on a CPU-only machine

10. Sources

S01. Capital FM / AFP, 16 September 2018 - Ethiopia, Eritrea seek to bolster truce at Saudi summit.
https://capitalfm.africa/ethiopia-eritrea-seek-to-bolster-truce-at-saudi-summit/

S02. UAE Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 16 September 2018 - UAE at the Jeddah signing.
https://www.mofa.gov.ae/en/mediahub/news/2019/2018/9/16/16-09-2018-uae-jeddah

S03. Somaliland Chronicle, 13 March 2019 - Ethiopia and France sign military and navy deal.
https://somalilandchronicle.com/2019/03/13/ethiopia-france-sign-military-navy-deal-turn-new-page-in-ties/

S04. PAX - Turkish drones join Ethiopia's war, satellite imagery confirms.
https://paxforpeace.nl/news/turkish-drones-join-ethiopias-war-satellite-imagery-confirms/

S05. Digit (site36), 5 January 2022 - War in Ethiopia: armed drones could again be a game changer.
https://digit.site36.net/2022/01/05/war-in-ethiopia-armed-drones-could-be-again-a-gamechanger/

S06. The EastAfrican - US: Iran supplied Ethiopia with armed drones in Tigray war.
https://theeastafrican.co.ke/tea/news/eastern-africa/us-iran-gave-ethiopia-armed-drones-in-tigray-war-3991732

S07. Overt Defense - Ethiopian Air Force receives Russian Su-30 aircraft and Turkish Akinci UAVs.
https://overtdefense.com/tag/su-30

S08. Citizen Digital (Reuters) - Somalia rejects port deal between Ethiopia and Somaliland.
https://citizen.digital/article/somalia-rejects-port-deal-between-ethiopia-and-somaliland-n334107

S09. The Defense Post, 22 February 2024 - Somalia defense deal with Turkey.
https://thedefensepost.com/2024/02/22/somalia-defense-deal-turkey/amp/

S10. Al Jazeera, 10 October 2024 - Somalia, Eritrea and Egypt pledge to bolster security ties.
https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2024/10/10/somalia-eritera-and-egypt-pledge-to-bloster-security-ties

S11. Daily News Egypt - Egypt, Eritrea, Somalia leaders hold tripartite summit in Asmara.
https://www.dailynewsegypt.com/?p=821995

S12. Türkiye MFA, 11 December 2024 - Ankara Declaration.
https://www.mfa.gov.tr/etiyopya-federal-demokratik-cumhuriyeti-ve-somali-federal-cumhuriyeti-nin-ankara-bildirisi.en.mfa

S13. Times of Israel - Netanyahu looks to boost security coordination with Ethiopia (2025 contacts).
https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/netanyahu-looks-to-boost-security-coordination-with-ethiopia/

S14. Al-Monitor, September 2025 - Ethiopia inaugurates Africa's biggest dam, drawing Egyptian protest.
https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2025/09/ethiopia-inaugurates-africas-biggest-dam-drawing-egyptian-protest

S15. Khaleej Times, December 2025 - Somalia, African nations condemn Israel's recognition of Somaliland.
https://www.khaleejtimes.com/world/africa/somalia-african-nations-condemn-israel-recognition-somaliland

S16. Egypt Independent, December 2025 - Israel becomes first country to formally recognize Somaliland.
https://www.egyptindependent.com/israel-becomes-first-country-to-formally-recognize-somaliland-as-independent-state/

S17. AllAfrica, 25 February 2026 - Israeli President arrives in Addis Ababa for two-day official visit.
https://allafrica.com/stories/202602250221.html

S18. Africanews, 9 February 2026 - Ethiopia-Eritrea tensions: fears of armed confrontation grow.
https://www.africanews.com/2026/02/09/ethiopia-eritrea-tensions-fears-of-armed-confontation-grow/

Completion criteria: every historical statement in the approved graph links to a source passage; no synthetic persona is presented as a real person; real officials and institutions are context-only in simulations; simulated results are never reported as public opinion or forecasts.